

Samurai victorious
One of very few peoples to defeat the Mongols in the 13th century, the Japanese repelled an attempted invasion by Kublai Khan in 1281. Here, Samurai defend a stone wall built along the coast to prevent the invading army from landing.

in 1294, the Mongols ruled all of China and Central Asia, and parts of the Middle East and eastern Europe. Western Europe escaped conquest purely because of distance – but when Mongol horsemen fought Christian knights at Liegnitz in 1241, the knights were crushed.

CHRISTIAN EUROPE

In the early medieval period, Western Europe was a relatively backward region dominated by Germanic peoples whose military system was based on the tribal warband. The region was exposed to aggressive raids and settlement by Muslims, Magyars, and Vikings. The Franks, by the 9th century claiming to be the successors to the Roman Empire in the west, struggled to defend their Christian domain, depending more upon cultural absorption than military might. The feared Vikings intermarried with Frankish subjects and adopted the French language; as Normans, indistinguishable from other Christian warriors, they conquered Anglo-Saxon England, Sicily, and southern Italy in the 11th century.

CHIVALROUS KNIGHTS

It was in that century that the armoured knight emerged as an elite warrior in medieval Europe. The special status of knighthood was conferred by public ceremony, celebrated in literature, and buttressed by the code of chivalry. Committed to close-quarters combat with lance and sword as the only honourable form of warfare, knights benefited from progress in metalworking that over time produced highly effective edged weapons and plate armour. In the 1090s European knights embarked upon the first of the Crusades, an aggressive onslaught upon Muslim rule in the eastern Mediterranean. Some knights belonged to military orders such as the Hospitallers and Templars, modelled upon orders of monks. The wearing of the cross, however, did not stop crusaders sacking Christian Constantinople in 1204. By the end of the 13th century the crusaders had been driven out of Palestine, but crusades continued around the margins of Christian Europe – against the Muslims in Spain and "pagan" peoples to the east.

INFANTRY AND GUNS

Since there was also near constant warfare between Christian states within Europe, the continent became a testing ground for fighting techniques and military technologies. Although the knight was regarded as the only true warrior, the search for success on the battlefield led to the development of more effective ways of using infantry. Lower-class foot soldiers, armed with pikes or halberds, and archers armed with the crossbow or longbow, were the most effective. Gunpowder weapons were probably first used on a European battlefield at Crécy in 1346, and cannon were improved through refinements in gunpowder manufacture and metal casting. By the second half of the 15th century, the combination of gunpowder weapons and better infantry brought an end to the dominance of armoured cavalry on European battlefields.

SEPARATE DEVELOPMENTS

In some parts of the world military developments followed their own path, with little influence from Eurasia. In Japan, the samurai resembled a medieval knight in being a warrior whose conduct was theoretically governed by a chivalric code, *bushido*. But the samurai had no equivalent of the mass cavalry charge with lances, nor did they despise the use of missile weapons, for the bow was initially their arm of choice.

In Central and South Americas a separate tradition of warfare had been established over millennia. In the absence of horses, battles were fought on foot, almost exclusively with weapons of wood and stone. Sophisticated empires had been built upon these limited military bases, but they were ill-equipped to survive the invasion by Europeans with horses, swords, armour, and gunpowder weapons in the 16th century.





